Live drawing

Building a representation step by step

Use live drawing to build a representation in the same sequence as the explanation. Clarity and purpose matter more than artistic polish.

How to do it well

1 Connect and display. Start with a blank surface, confirm visibility and link the representation to relevant prior knowledge.

2 Draw and label gradually. Narrate the concept as each element appears; keep the visual simple and essential.

3 Pause and read. Stop speaking while students read labels or annotations so verbal and visual information do not compete.

4 Explain and point. Trace arrows, point to the current feature and check understanding before adding more.

5 Recreate and rehearse. Students copy, label, predict or explain the representation so the task is active rather than observational.

What this sounds like

“I will add one arrow at a time. Explain what this connection represents before I draw the next one. Then complete the missing part on your own diagram.”

Classroom example. In Geography, a teacher draws a simple process diagram in the order events occur, adding arrows and labels gradually. Pupils explain each connection before completing a missing stage independently. The drawing makes the causal sequence visible; students are not judged on reproducing an artistic copy of the finished diagram.

Top tips that make the technique work

Start with the meaning. Decide which relationship the diagram will explain before deciding how attractive it should look.

Rehearse the strokes. Plan the order so the emerging drawing supports the spoken sequence.

Label gradually. Keep words close to the relevant part and pause while students read them.

Use pointing and tracing. Show how an arrow, boundary or connection represents the concept.

Ask students to recreate meaning. They can complete a missing part or explain a relationship rather than merely copy the finished picture.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Build the diagram in coherent stages.	Complex artwork that hides the concept.
Rehearse the relationship it represents.	Drawing every label before students know what to attend to.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

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